Eulogy for Colonel Billie H. Parker – April 13, 2026

A few years ago, / Bill and I shared a laugh.

We chuckled about the irony… / that I, a “blue-water” enlisted Navy guy, //
would one day stand here… / and give a eulogy…
for him… / a decorated Air Force “full bird” Colonel.

And yet— // here we are.

And I can say this with confidence— // Bill would be just fine with it.

Because he knew that these words… / are **coming from a friend**. //

---------- 1

Bill’s life… has come full circle. //

Here— / in the place where he grew up.
Here— / where his parents… and his friends…
helped shape who he would become.

And now here— / laid to rest beside his father and mother…
Good people. Houston… and Mary Parker. //

Even then… / maybe without even realizing it…
Bill was a rich young man. //

---------- 2

Can you imagine… / coming of age when he did? //

The great war was behind them.
Hard years… had passed.

And there was something in the air — // optimism.

Opportunity. //

Bill stepped into that.

He was ready to work.
Ready to explore. //

---------- 3

As a young teenager…
he ran the projector at the Seminole movie theater.

He talked about sitting up there with his dad…

watching films from the projection room.

He worked on cars.
Motorcycles.
He loved music. //

Bill was a curious man.

A builder.
A thinker.
A learner. //

And that never left him.

Even at 92 … Playing instruments …
… reading old encyclopedias …
still trying to understand the world. //

---------- 4

One of his early influences…
was a barber in town—
who also ran the Civil Air Patrol. /

That man told Bill… "You should learn to fly."

And Bill listened. //

By sixteen…
he was landing airplanes
at the Seminole airport. //

---------- 5

And then there was Jo Anna. //

The Maxwell family…
he grew up around them.
The girls thought of him like a brother…

At least at first. //

But Bill… / saw things a little differently.

He fell in love…
with Jo Anna Maxwell.

And she became his wife. / He was 24…, she 20. Both young and vibrant. //

And here they are—

just two months shy…
of 69 years together. //

That says something. //

---------- 6

Like all of us…
their life had turns.

Highs.
Lows.
Changes. //

And over time… life shapes a person. //

Bill changed… / in some ways.

But the core of who he was—
that stayed visible.

Strong.
Steady.

Faithful… //

---------- 7

And that brings us… to something deeper. //

A life… is never just one thing. //

It's not just success.
Not just failure.
Not just joy.
Not just regret. //

It's all of it… woven together. //

And when we gather like this—
we're not just remembering what a man did…

We're asking—
what did his life mean? //

---------- 8

The Bible speaks plainly about this. //

Ecclesiastes 7:20 says: "**There is not one truly righteous person… who always does good and never sins.**" //

That levels the ground. //

No life is perfect.

Not yours.
Not mine.
Not Bill's. //

And yet— // that is not the end of the story. //

Because Scripture shows us something else—

That a life can be dignified…
even with imperfections. //

---------- 9

You've probably heard the phrase—
"No man is an island." //

The 17th century English pastor, John Donne,
said it this way: //

"No man is an island…
any man's death diminishes me…
because I am involved in mankind…
and therefore, never send to know
for whom the bell tolls…
it tolls for thee." //

That's why this moment matters. //

Because Bill's life…
does not stand alone. //

It touches yours.
It touches mine.

And now… his passing touches us. //

---------- 10

When you think about Bill…

You think about presence. //

How he showed up.
How he spoke.
How he carried himself. //

And if you knew him— you knew this: //

He was always engaged.

Always thinking.
Always curious.
Always accomplishing.

Whether it was machines…
ideas…
music…
or people. //

Even late in life—
he was still learning.
Still asking questions. //

That kind of life…
leaves a mark. //

---------- 11

But we also need to be honest. //

Every life… carries regret. //

Things we wish we had said.
Things we wish we hadn't said.
Moments we mishandled.
Opportunities we missed. //

Scripture doesn't hide that. //

Romans 3:23 says: "**All have sinned… and fall short of the Glory of God.**" //

All… *means all*. //

---------- 12

But here is where hope enters. //

The story… does not end with regret. //

It moves toward grace. //

1 John 1:9 says: "**If we confess… He is faithful… to forgive.**" //

That changes everything. //

Because a life is not measured by perfection.

It is measured… by direction. //

By where the heart turns. //

---------- 13

And each of us… is still in that story. //

Still choosing direction.
Still deciding… where our trust will rest. //

The **grace** Scripture speaks of—
is not just for Bill. //

It is for you. **Today**. //

---------- 14

Bill lived… like all of us…
between strength and weakness. /

Between confidence… and reflection. /

Between doing well…
and knowing he could have done better. //

That's not failure. //

That's being human. //

---------- 15

Psalm 90:12 says: "**Teach us to consider our mortality… so we may live wisely.**" /

That's what Bill's life does today. //

It teaches us. //

Not just about Bill—

but about ourselves. //

It reminds us—
that time is limited. //

That the people sitting around you… matter. //

That the conversations we put off…
shouldn't be put off. //

That faith… is not for later.
It is for now. //

Because in the end—
what we carry in our hearts…
matters more than anything we accomplish. //

---------- 16

If Bill were standing here…
he wouldn't want a long list. //

He would want something simple. //

That he lived.
Tat he loved.
That he tried.
That he believed. //

And that… by Grace through Faith in Jesus Christ alone…
God would impute righteousness to him as He promises. //

Jesus said in John 14:
"**I go to prepare a place for you…**
and I will come again…
and take you to be with me." //

That is our hope today. //

Not because of the lives we have woven—
but because God is faithful… to redeem them. //

---------- 17

So, we remember Bill… not as a perfect man—

but as a real man. //

A man who lived.
Who learned.

Who believed— //

And who now rests… the hands of a faithful God. //

Closing Prayer

Lord God, //

We come to You…
with gratitude… and humility. //

Thank You for Bill—
for his life…
for his love…
and for the ways he touched ours. //

You know the whole story—
the strengths… and the weaknesses…
the joys… and the regrets. //

And we trust in Your mercy. //

Thank You that You forgive.
That Your grace is greater… than our sin. //

Bring comfort now… to those who grieve.
Bring peace… to this family. //

Remind us… that our hope is not in ourselves…
but in You. //

Teach us to live wisely.
To love deeply.
To walk humbly before You. //

And we rest in Your promise—
that to be absent from the body…
is to be at home with the Lord. //

In Jesus' name, //
Amen. //